MANDARIN ZEST
中文皮

PHRASE GUIDE

Essential Mandarin Phrases for Everyday Life

The phrases you'll actually use: greeting people, ordering food, getting around, paying and asking for help, with pinyin and a note on when to use each one.

你好

100	**phrases** with pinyin, meaning and usage notes
10	**real-life situations**, from restaurants to emergencies
10	**must-know phrases** to learn first



BEFORE YOU START

How to use this guide

1. **Start with the top 10.** They cover most first conversations on their own.
2. **Learn by situation.** Before a trip, a dinner or a hotel stay, review that one section.
3. **Say them out loud.** Read the pinyin with its tones, then try again from the characters only.
4. **Read the notes.** They tell you when a phrase sounds natural, and when it doesn't.
5. **Tick the box** once you can say the phrase without looking.

LEARN THESE 10 FIRST

1 你好 **nǐ hǎo** Hello	2 谢谢 **xièxie** Thank you	3 不好意思 **bù hǎoyìsi** Excuse me / sorry	4 这个多少钱? **zhège duōshao qián?** How much is this?	5 我要这个 **wǒ yào zhège** I'll take this
6 …在哪里? **... zài nǎlǐ?** Where is...?	7 买单 **mǎidān** The bill, please	8 请帮我一下 **qǐng bāng wǒ yíxià** Please help me	9 请说慢一点 **qǐng shuō màn yìdiǎn** Please speak more slowly	10 没关系 **méi guānxi** It's okay / no worries

The 10 situations

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01 Greetings and Goodbyes

11 phrases · First words and goodbyes

你好
nǐ hǎo

CHINESE	MEANING	NOTES
你好 nǐ hǎo	**Hello**	Said ní hǎo: two 3rd tones in a row, so the first becomes a 2nd tone
您好 nín hǎo	**Hello (respectful)**	For elders, teachers and bosses
嗨 / 嘿 hāi / hēi	**Hi / Hey**	What people actually say to friends
早 zǎo	**Morning**	The casual version of 早上好, just the first character
你干嘛呢? nǐ gànma ne?	**What are you up to?**	More natural than 你好吗? among friends
吃了吗? chī le ma?	**Have you eaten?**	Works like "How are you?". Answer: 吃了, 你呢?
再见 zàijiàn	**Goodbye**	A bit formal: friends often say 拜拜 or 走了
拜拜 bāibāi	**Bye**	The casual, everyday goodbye
走了 zǒu le	**I'm heading out**	Said when leaving a group
回头见 huítóu jiàn	**See you later**	Implies you'll meet again soon
明天见 míngtiān jiàn	**See you tomorrow**	Simple and practical

02 Introducing Yourself

7 phrases · Name, origin and small talk

我
wǒ

CHINESE	MEANING	NOTES
我叫… wǒ jiào...	**My name is...**	Literally "I am called...", more natural than 我的名字是…
我来自… wǒ lái zì...	**I'm from...**	我是从…来的 (wǒ shì cóng... lái de) also works
很高兴认识你 hěn gāoxìng rènshi nǐ	**Nice to meet you**	Said after being introduced
我在学中文 wǒ zài xué Zhōngwén	**I'm learning Chinese**	This will always make people smile
我的中文不太好，请多指教 wǒ de Zhōngwén bú tài hǎo, qǐng duō zhǐjiào	**My Chinese isn't very good, please bear with me**	A humble way to set expectations. People appreciate it
请问您怎么称呼? qǐngwèn nín zěnme chēnghu?	**May I ask your name?**	More polite than 你叫什么名字?
我想了解更多中国文化 wǒ xiǎng liǎojiě gèng duō Zhōngguó wénhuà	**I want to learn more about Chinese culture**	A phrase that genuinely opens conversations

03 At a Restaurant

15 phrases · Ordering, allergies and the bill

吃
chī

CHINESE	MEANING	NOTES
服务员! fúwùyuán!	**Excuse me! (to a waiter)**	Calls a server's attention. Say it loudly if needed
麻烦给我拿一下菜单 máfan gěi wǒ ná yíxià càidān	**Could you bring me the menu?**	麻烦 (máfan) softens requests: "sorry for the trouble, could you..."
两位 / 三位 liǎng wèi / sān wèi	**Table for two / three**	位 is the polite measure word for people
请给我来个这个 qǐng gěi wǒ lái ge zhège	**I'll have this one**	Point at the menu. Extremely useful
这个多少钱? zhège duōshao qián?	**How much is this?**	Works everywhere, not just in restaurants
这个是什么做的? zhège shì shénme zuò de?	**What is this made of?**	Essential for allergies and dietary restrictions
我对…过敏 wǒ duì... guòmǐn	**I'm allergic to...**	Fill in the blank: 花生 (huāshēng, peanuts), 海鲜 (hǎixiān, seafood)
我吃素 wǒ chī sù	**I'm vegetarian**	Simpler than asking for a vegetarian menu
不要辣 bú yào là	**No spicy, please**	Essential with Sichuan and Hunan food
请不要放味精 qǐng bú yào fàng wèijīng	**No MSG, please**	Useful for food sensitivities
好吃! hǎochī!	**Delicious!**	Say this and your host's day is made
买单 mǎidān	**The bill, please**	The usual way to ask. 结账 (jiézhàng) also works
我可以打包吗? wǒ kěyǐ dǎbāo ma?	**Can I get this to go?**	打包 (dǎbāo) literally means "pack it up"
干杯! gānbēi!	**Cheers!**	Literally "dry cup": you are expected to finish the drink
随意 suíyì	**As you like / no need to finish**	Said so nobody feels obliged to 干杯

04 Shopping

10 phrases · Prices, sizes and paying

买
mǎi

CHINESE	MEANING	NOTES
这个多少钱? ALSO ABOVE zhège duōshao qián?	**How much?**	Works for anything
太贵了 tài guì le	**Too expensive**	The starting point of any market negotiation
便宜点可以吗? piányi diǎn kěyǐ ma?	**Can you go cheaper?**	A polite bargaining opener
我只是看看 wǒ zhǐshì kànkan	**I'm just looking**	Useful when vendors are pushy
我要这个 wǒ yào zhège	**I'll take this**	Simple and direct
有没有大/小一点的? yǒu méiyǒu dà/xiǎo yìdiǎn de?	**Do you have a bigger/ smaller size?**	Useful when shopping for clothes or shoes
我可以试一下吗? wǒ kěyǐ shì yíxià ma?	**Can I try this on?**	Common in clothing stores
能用微信支付吗? néng yòng Wēixìn Zhīfù ma?	**Can I pay with WeChat Pay?**	Essential in mainland China, where cash is increasingly unusual
能刷卡吗? néng shuā kǎ ma?	**Can I pay by card?**	Cards work in hotels and malls, rarely in markets
可以开发票吗? kěyǐ kāi fāpiào ma?	**Can I have a receipt?**	发票 (fāpiào) is the official tax receipt, not a regular receipt

05 Getting Around

11 phrases · Directions, taxis and the metro

走
zǒu

CHINESE	MEANING	NOTES
请问…在哪里? qǐngwèn… zài nǎlǐ?	**Excuse me, where is…?**	请问 softens the question: "may I ask…"
…怎么走? … zěnme zǒu?	**How do I get to…?**	Literally "how do I walk to…"
我要去… wǒ yào qù…	**I want to go to…**	For taxis and DiDi: show the address in Chinese on your phone
最近的地铁站在哪里? zuìjìn de dìtiě zhàn zài nǎlǐ?	**Where's the nearest metro station?**	Useful in any Chinese city
去…多少钱? qù… duōshao qián?	**How much to go to…?**	For taxis
就在这里停 jiù zài zhèlǐ tíng	**Stop here, please**	Useful when giving directions to a driver
向左转 / 向右转 xiàng zuǒ zhuǎn / xiàng yòu zhuǎn	**Turn left / Turn right**	Basic navigation phrases
直走 zhí zǒu	**Go straight**	One of the most common directions
我迷路了 wǒ mílù le	**I'm lost**	Helpful in emergencies
扫码 sǎo mǎ	**Scan the QR code**	You'll hear and see this everywhere
叫个滴滴 jiào ge Dīdī	**Get a DiDi (ride-hail)**	滴滴 is mainland China's Uber, essential for getting around cities

06 At the Hotel

8 phrases · Check-in, WiFi and breakfast

住
zhù

CHINESE	MEANING	NOTES
我预订了一个房间 wǒ yùdìng le yí ge fángjiān	**I have a reservation**	Useful at hotel check-in
我叫… wǒ jiào...	**My name is...**	For check-in
办理入住 bànlǐ rùzhù	**Check in**	Formal hotel term
退房 tuìfáng	**Check out**	Standard hotel term
WiFi密码是什么? WiFi mìmǎ shì shénme?	**What's the WiFi password?**	Priority number one for most travellers
早餐几点开始? zǎocān jǐ diǎn kāishǐ?	**What time is breakfast?**	Common hotel question
退房时间是几点? tuìfáng shíjiān shì jǐ diǎn?	**What time is check-out?**	Always good to confirm
空调怎么用? kōngtiáo zěnme yòng?	**How does the air conditioning work?**	More useful than you'd think

ALSO ABOVE

07 Digital Life and WeChat

7 phrases · WeChat, QR codes and payments

网
wǎng

CHINESE	MEANING	NOTES
你有微信吗? nǐ yǒu Wēixìn ma?	**Do you have WeChat?**	WeChat is how everyone in mainland China communicates
加一下微信 jiā yíxià Wēixìn	**Let's connect on WeChat**	More common than exchanging phone numbers
扫我的二维码 sǎo wǒ de èrwéimǎ	**Scan my QR code**	How WeChat contacts are added
微信支付 / 支付宝 Wēixìn Zhīfù / Zhīfùbǎo	**WeChat Pay / Alipay**	The two dominant payment apps
没网 méi wǎng	**No internet**	When your VPN or connection isn't working
发给我 fā gěi wǒ	**Send it to me**	For files, photos and locations on WeChat
线上 / 线下 xiànshàng / xiànxià	**Online / offline**	A common distinction in business and daily life

08 Help and Emergencies

12 phrases · When something goes wrong

救
jiù

CHINESE	MEANING	NOTES
请帮我一下 qǐng bāng wǒ yíxià	**Please help me**	Polite and widely useful
救命! jiùmìng!	**Help!**	Emergency only: literally "save my life"
叫警察 jiào jǐngchá	**Call the police**	Police: 110 in mainland China and Taiwan
叫救护车 jiào jiùhùchē	**Call an ambulance**	Ambulance: 120 in mainland China, 119 in Taiwan
我需要医生 wǒ xūyào yīshēng	**I need a doctor**	Direct and clear in emergencies
我不舒服 wǒ bù shūfu	**I'm not feeling well**	The common way to say you feel ill
我的护照丢了 wǒ de hùzhào diū le	**I've lost my passport**	Report it to the police right away: your embassy will need the report
我被偷了 wǒ bèi tōu le	**I've been robbed**	Important for emergencies and reporting
我对…过敏 ALSO ABOVE wǒ duì... guòmǐn	**I'm allergic to...**	Fill in, e.g. 花生 (peanuts), 海鲜 (seafood)
我不懂，你能再说一遍吗? wǒ bù dǒng, nǐ néng zài shuō yí biàn ma?	**I don't understand, could you repeat that?**	Very useful in stressful situations
请说慢一点 qǐng shuō màn yìdiǎn	**Please speak more slowly**	Helps in emergencies or confusion
你会说英语吗? nǐ huì shuō Yīngyǔ ma?	**Do you speak English?**	One of the most important survival phrases

09 Polite Social Phrases

11 phrases · Thanks, apologies and kindness

谢
xiè

CHINESE	MEANING	NOTES
谢谢 xièxie	**Thank you**	Universal
谢谢啦 xièxie la	**Thanks**	Lighter, more casual
麻烦你了 máfan nǐ le	**Sorry for the trouble**	Said with thanks when someone helped you
不用谢 bú yòng xiè	**Don't mention it**	The standard reply to being thanked
没事 méishì	**No problem / It's fine**	When someone apologises
对不起 duìbuqǐ	**Sorry**	For genuine apologies
不好意思 bù hǎoyìsi	**Excuse me / I'm sorry (mild)**	For small inconveniences: "sorry to bother you"
没关系 méi guānxi	**It doesn't matter**	The reply to an apology
请 qǐng	**Please**	Used before verbs: 请坐 (please sit)
随便 suíbiàn	**As you like / whatever you prefer**	Used when leaving a choice to someone else
辛苦了 xīnkǔ le	**You've worked hard**	A warm phrase acknowledging effort

10 Yes, No and Agreement

8 phrases · Saying yes and saying no

对
duì

CHINESE	MEANING	NOTES
对 duì	**Correct / Right**	Confirming a fact
好 hǎo	**Okay / Good**	Agreeing to a plan or suggestion
行 xíng	**That works / Sure**	Confirming something is doable
好的 hǎo de	**Okay / Alright**	Softer than 好, very common in messages
当然 dāngrán	**Of course**	A strong yes
没问题 méi wèntí	**No problem**	Agreeing easily, "no issue"
不行 bù xíng	**That won't work**	A clear, direct refusal
不太方便 bú tài fāngbiàn	**Not very convenient**	A soft, indirect "no" that avoids a blunt refusal

NEXT STEP

Ready to use these phrases for real?

Reading a phrase is the easy part. Saying it with confidence comes from using it out loud with real people.

SPEAKING PRACTICE

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